

757: NON-STATE ACTORS IN WORLD AFFAIRS

Spring 2027

Instructor:	Takumi Shibaike
Email:	tshibaik@syr.edu
Time:	Wednesday 3:30 PM–6:15 PM
Location:	Eggers Hall 100A
Office Hours:	TBD

1 Course Description

Who governs the world? While states are often assumed to be the default governors in world politics, a substantial body of research shows that non-state actors are accepted as legitimate governors in many parts of the world and across diverse issue areas. This course examines a wide range of non-state actors, including rebel groups, criminal organizations, nongovernmental organizations, religious organizations, and multinational corporations. We investigate how and why non-state actors come to exercise authority at the global level, how they interact with states and international organizations, and what their growing role means for power, legitimacy, and accountability in world politics.

2 Assessment

2.1 Schedule and Weighting

Participation	20%	Every Week
Discussion Report	20%	Sign up by Week 3 (first come, first serve)
Peer Review	20%	April 7
Presentation Session	10%	April 14
Research Paper	30%	April 21

Extension

You must notify me *prior to* the deadline to avoid late penalties for each assignment. Keep in mind that you may be asked to provide documentation.

Participation

The participation component of your grade is based on the quality of your contribution to in-class discussions. Participation is more than just attendance. You are expected to listen actively, express your thoughts verbally, and raise questions with some regularity.

Absence

You may take absence from class with valid reasons. You must notify me *prior to* the class in order to avoid penalties on your participation grade. Documentation is not required for your first absence but it is required thereafter. Please do not come to class if you are sick.

Zoom policy

When our class is held on Zoom, you must join using a laptop or desktop computer. Phones should not be used for Zoom participation, as they limit your ability to fully engage in class exercises.

Academic freedom

In order to ensure academic freedom in classroom, you must maintain confidentiality of who said what in discussions. Do not distribute course materials outside the class without the instructor's written permission.

AI rules

In addition to the AI policy listed under University Policy below, the use of AI in this course is limited to stylistic matters, such as formatting and grammar checks.

3 Class Schedule

January 13: States

Required readings

Tilly, Charles. "War Making and State Making as Organized Crime." In Evans, Peter B., et al. *Bringing the State Back In*. Cambridge University Press, 1985.

North, Douglass C., and Barry R. Weingast. "Constitutions and commitment: the evolution of institutions governing public choice in seventeenth-century England." *The Journal of Economic History* 49.4 (1989): 803-832.

Recommended readings

Weber, Max. "Politics as a Vocation." 1919.

Gellner, Ernest. *Nations and nationalism*. Cornell University Press, 2008.

January 20: Structure and Agency

Required readings

Wendt, Alexander. "The agent-structure problem in international relations theory." *International Organization* 41.3 (1987): 335-370.

Hollis, Martin, and Steve Smith. "Beware of gurus: structure and action in international relations." *Review of International Studies* 17.4 (1991): 393-410.

Recommended readings

Barnett, Michael, and Raymond Duvall. "Power in international politics." *International Organization* 59.1 (2005): 39-75.

Wendt, Alexander. *Social theory of international politics*. Cambridge University Press, 1999.

January 27: NGOs

Required readings

Finnemore, Martha, and Kathryn Sikkink. "International norm dynamics and political change." *International Organization* 52.4 (1998): 887-917.

Carpenter, R. Charli. "Vetting the advocacy agenda: Network centrality and the paradox of weapons norms." *International Organization* 65.1 (2011): 69-102.

Eilstrup-Sangiovanni, Mette, and Teale N. Phelps Bondaroff. "From advocacy to confrontation: Direct enforcement by environmental NGOs." *International Studies Quarterly* 58.2 (2014): 348-361.

Recommended readings

Keck, Margaret E., and Kathryn Sikkink. *Activists beyond borders: Advocacy networks in international politics*. Cornell University Press, 1998.

Stroup, Sarah S., and Wendy H. Wong. *The authority trap: Strategic choices of international NGOs*. Cornell University Press, 2018.

Bush Sarah S., Hadden Jennifer. *Crowded Out: The Competitive Landscape of Contemporary International NGOs*. Cambridge University Press, 2025.

February 3: Rebel Groups

Required readings

Fearon, James D., and David D. Laitin. "Ethnicity, insurgency, and civil war." *American Political Science Review* 97.1 (2003): 75-90.

Stewart, Megan A. "Civil war as state-making: Strategic governance in civil war." *International Organization* 72.1 (2018): 205-226.

Huang, Reyko. "Rebel diplomacy in civil war." *International Security* 40.4 (2016): 89-126.

Recommended readings

Loyle, Cyanne E., et al. "New directions in rebel governance research." *Perspectives on Politics* 21.1 (2023): 264-276.

Fazal, Tanisha M., and Margarita Konaev. "Homelands versus minelands: Why do armed groups commit to the laws of war?." *Journal of Global Security Studies* 4.2 (2019): 149-168.

Griffiths, Ryan D. *Secession and the sovereignty game: Strategy and tactics for aspiring nations*. Cornell University Press, 2021.

March 3: Criminal Groups

Required readings

Jung, Danielle F., and Dara Kay Cohen. *Lynching and local justice: Legitimacy and accountability in weak states*. Cambridge University Press, 2020.

Fujii, Lee Ann. "The puzzle of extra-lethal violence." *Perspectives on Politics* 11.2 (2013): 410-426.

Lessing, Benjamin. "Conceptualizing criminal governance." *Perspectives on Politics* 19.3 (2021): 854-873.

Recommended readings

Lessing, Benjamin, and Graham Denyer Willis. "Legitimacy in criminal governance: Managing a drug empire from behind bars." *American Political Science Review* 113.2 (2019): 584-606.

February 10: Corporations

Required readings

Sell, Susan K., and Aseem Prakash. "Using ideas strategically: The contest between business and NGO networks in intellectual property rights." *International Studies Quarterly* 48.1 (2004): 143-175.

Haufler, Virginia. "Disclosure as governance: The extractive industries transparency initiative and resource management in the developing world." *Global Environmental Politics* 10.3 (2010): 53-73.

Alger, Justin, Kate J. Neville, and Marc Calabretta. "The emerging political economy of deep-sea mining: an analysis of opaque ownership structures." *Review of International Political Economy* 33.1 (2026): 193-222.

Recommended readings

Green, Jessica, et al. "Transition, hedge, or resist? Understanding political and economic behavior toward decarbonization in the oil and gas industry." *Review of International Political Economy* 29.6 (2022): 2036-2063.

Bütte, Tim. "Private regulation in the global economy: A (p) review." *Business and Politics* 12.3 (2010): 1-38.

February 17: Experts

Required readings

Haas, Peter M. "Introduction: epistemic communities and international policy coordination." *International Organization* 46.1 (1992): 1-35.

Beaumont, Paul, and Ole Jacob Sending. "Governance by indicators and the re-politicisation of expertise." *Review of International Studies* (2026): 1-19.

Recommended readings

Seabrooke, Leonard, and Duncan Wigan. "Powering ideas through expertise: professionals in global tax battles." *Journal of European Public Policy* 23.3 (2016): 357-374.

February 24: Big Tech

Required readings

Wong, Wendy H., Jamie Duncan, and David A. Lake. "Why data about people are so hard to govern." *Regulation & Governance* 19.1 (2025): 236-252.

Beaumier, Guillaume, and Lars Gjesvik. "Digital governance in a rubber band: Structural constraints in governing a global digital economy." *Global Studies Quarterly* 5.2 (2025): ksaf043.

Recommended readings

Zuboff, Shoshana. "Surveillance capitalism and the challenge of collective action." *New labor forum*. Vol. 28. No. 1. Sage CA: Los Angeles, CA: Sage Publications, 2019.

Wong, Wendy H., and David A. Lake. "Governing Artificial Intelligence: Designing Professional Structures for the Predictive Age." *Ethics & International Affairs* 39.4 (2025): 312-335.

Srivastava, Swati. "Algorithmic governance and the international politics of big tech." *Perspectives on politics* 21.3 (2023): 989-1000.

March 10: Spring(?) Break

March 17: Religious Organizations

Required readings

Hall, Rodney Bruce. "Moral authority as a power resource." *International Organization* 51.4 (1997): 591-622.

Bob, Clifford. *Globalizing the Right-Wing: Conservative Activism and Transnational Politics*. Cambridge University Press, 2012.

Byman, Daniel. "Understanding the Islamic state—a review essay." *International Security* 40.4 (2016): 127-165.

Recommended readings

Sheikh, Mona Kanwal. "How does religion matter? Pathways to religion in International Relations." *Review of International Studies* 38.2 (2012): 365-392.

March 24: ISA Debrief

March 31: Hybrids

Required readings

Srivastava, Swati. *Hybrid sovereignty in world politics*. Cambridge University Press, 2022.

Forum Article on ISR

Recommended readings

Srivastava, Swati. "Corporate sovereign awakening and the making of modern state sovereignty: New archival evidence from the English East India Company." *International Organization* 76.3 (2022): 690-712.

April 7: Peer Review

Deadline: Please send your preliminary draft to me by **11:59 PM on April 6**.

You will conduct a peer review of your classmates' final paper drafts. Your peer review is due by the end of this meeting.

April 14: Presentations

You will present your paper.

April 21: No Class

Work on your final paper.

Deadline: Please send your final draft to me by **11:59 PM on April 21**.

4 University Policy

4.1 Academic Integrity

Syracuse University's [Academic Integrity Policy](#) reflects the high value that we, as a university community, place on honesty in academic work. The policy holds students accountable for the integrity of all work they submit and for upholding course-specific, as well as university-wide, academic integrity expectations. The policy governs citation and use of sources, the integrity of work submitted in exams and assignments, and truthfulness in all academic matters, including course attendance and participation.

The policy states that any work a student submits for a course must be solely their own unless the instructor explicitly allows collaboration or editing. The policy also requires students to acknowledge their use of other peoples' language, images or other original creative or scholarly work through appropriate citation. These expectations extend to the new, fast-growing realm of artificial intelligence (AI) as well as to the use of websites that charge fees or require uploading of course materials to obtain exam solutions or assignments. Students are required to ask their instructor whether use of these tools is permitted—and if so, to what extent—before using them to complete any assignment or exam. Students are also required to seek advance permission from instructors if they wish to submit the same work in more than one course. Failure to receive this permission in advance may violate the [Academic Integrity Policy](#). Under the policy, instructors who seek to penalize a student for a suspected violation must first report the violation to the Center for Learning and Student Success (CLASS). Students may not drop or withdraw from courses in which they face a suspected violation. Instructors must wait to assign a final course grade until a suspected violation is reviewed and upheld or overturned.

Upholding Academic Integrity includes abiding by instructors' individual course expectations, which may include the protection of their intellectual property. Students should not upload, distribute, or otherwise share instructors' course materials without permission. Students found in violation of the policy are subject to grade sanctions determined by the course instructor and non-grade sanctions determined by the School or College where the course is offered, as outlined in the [Violation and Sanction Classification Rubric](#). Students are required to read an online summary of the University's academic integrity expectations and provide an electronic signature agreeing to abide by them twice a year during pre-term check-in on MySlice.

The [Violation and Sanction Classification Rubric](#) establishes recommended guidelines for the determination of grade penalties by faculty and instructors, while also giving them discretion to select the grade penalty they believe most suitable, including course failure, regardless of violation level. Any established violation in this course may result in course failure regardless of violation level.

4.2 No-recording and No-sharing Policy

This course strictly prohibits any unauthorized audio and/or video recording, in whole or in part, of any lecture or discussion section. In addition, course materials provided by instructors must not be distributed or otherwise shared without permission. Violations will be handled through Syracuse University's Academic Integrity Policy.

4.3 AI Policy

All generative-AI tools are prohibited in this course because their use inhibits achievement of the course learning objectives. This policy applies to all stages of project and writing processes including researching, brainstorming, outlining, organizing, and polishing. Do not use Generative-AI tools to create any content (i.e., images and video, audio, text, code, etc.). If you have any questions about a feature and whether it is considered Generative-AI, ask your instructor.

4.4 Attendance

Attendance in classes is expected in all courses at Syracuse University. It is a federal requirement that faculty promptly notify the university of students who do not attend or cease to attend any class. Faculty will use Early-Semester Progress Reports and Mid-Semester Progress Reports in Orange SUccess to alert the Registrar and Financial Aid Office on [non-attendance](#).

4.5 Disability

Syracuse University values diversity and inclusion; we are committed to a climate of mutual respect and full participation. There may be aspects of the instruction or design of this course that result in barriers to your inclusion and full participation in this course. I invite any student to contact me to discuss strategies and/or accommodations (academic adjustments) that may be essential to your success and to collaborate with the Center for Disability Resources (CDR) in this process.

If you would like to discuss disability-accommodations or register with CDR, please visit Center for Disability Resources. Please call (315) 443-4498 or email disabilityresources@syr.edu for more detailed information.

4.6 Discrimination or Harassment

Federal and state law, and University policy prohibit discrimination and harassment based on sex or gender (including sexual harassment, sexual assault, domestic/dating violence, stalking, sexual exploitation, and retaliation). If a student has been harassed or assaulted, they can obtain confidential counseling support, 24-hours a day, 7 days a week, from the [Sexual and Relationship Violence Response Team](#) at the Counseling Center (315-443-8000, Barnes Center at The Arch, 150 Sims Drive, Syracuse, New York 13244). Incidents of sexual violence or harassment can be reported non-confidentially to the University's Title IX Officer (Sheila Johnson Willis, 315-443-0211, titleix@syr.edu, 005 Steele Hall). Reports to law enforcement can be made to the University's Department of Public Safety (315-443-2224, 005 Sims Hall), the Syracuse Police Department (511 South State Street, Syracuse, New York, 911 in case of emergency or 315-435-3016 to speak with the Abused Persons Unit), or the State Police (844-845-7269). I will seek to keep information you share with me private to the greatest extent possible, but as a professor I have mandatory reporting responsibilities to share information regarding sexual misconduct, harassment, and crimes I learn about with the University's Title IX Officer to help make our campus a safer place for all.

4.7 Religious Observances

Syracuse University's [Religious Observances Policy](#) recognizes the diversity of faiths represented in the campus community and protects the rights of students, faculty, and staff to observe religious holy days according to their traditions. Under the policy, students are given an opportunity to make up any examination, study, or work requirements that may be missed due to a religious observance, provided they notify their instructors no later than the academic drop deadline. For observances occurring before the drop deadline, notification is required at least two academic days in advance. Students may enter their observances in MySlice under Student Services/Enrollment/My Religious Observances/Add a Notification.

4.8 Health and Wellness

Mental health and overall well-being are significant predictors of academic success. As such it is essential that during your college experience you develop the skills and resources effectively to navigate stress, anxiety, depression, and other mental health concerns. Please familiarize yourself with the range of [resources](#) the Barnes Center provides and seek out support for mental health concerns as needed. Counseling services are available 24/7, 365 days, at 315-443-8000, and I encourage you to explore the resources available through the [Wellness Leadership Institute](#).